

in the pre-frontal cortex or the slow-thinking part of our brain. The researchers in the experiment identified two regions in the brain: 'goal-directed decisions have their basis in a common value signal encoded in the ventromedial prefrontal cortex (vmPFC), while exercising self-control involves modulation of the value signal by the dorsolateral prefrontal cortex (DLPFC).' The researchers called those who were able to choose the healthy option 'self-controllers'.

To put it in plain English? Researchers discovered region vmPFC was activated when a value-based decision needed to be made. Do I want to choose chocolate or the healthier option of a piece of fruit? Do I want to continue saving for a house or take my savings and head off on a holiday to Bali? Whereas the DLPFC region was only activated for those who were seeking to exercise self-control. I've weighed up the benefits of taste vs health and decided to choose the piece of fruit. I'm tempted to scoot off to Bali but am choosing the long-term goal of buying my own home and will go camping instead. The DLPFC region tempers and modulates the vmPFC region. It's like an internal voice asking you if you really need to eat that entire block of chocolate or if you really need that new pair of shoes or would you benefit from exercising some self-control instead?

If we think about our finances for a moment, these findings have implications for those of us who don't have an active DLPFC region or who aren't natural 'self-controllers'. It suggests that there are in fact those of us who, because of how we're hardwired, will naturally look after our future self and will more easily delay gratification. While there are others who are more impatient, who will raid their savings account more readily—who have a propensity to instant gratification and seeking an immediate reward.

Which leads me to ask the question: Does this research suggest, therefore, that the widely held view that some of us are naturally spenders while others of us are naturally savers is in fact accurate? The answer, for those of you who identify as a spender, thankfully, is no.

Researchers such as Dr Anne Mostafa, a psychologist based in Bahrain, argue that our genes may bring about the tendency to spend or save, but they don't necessarily produce the behaviour. In an interview with Gulf News, Mostafa said, 'The environment and society exert the primary influence on whether the behaviour will appear or not. Biochemical